

Legal casework: document-controlled argumentation

Two community associations · one register · Norway, 2026

Two community associations were opposing a quarry expansion in western Norway. Neither had counsel. Both needed correspondence that a regulator would be obliged to answer in writing, on the record, before a zoning decision was taken — and it has since answered. The associations acted in their own name throughout; I built and ran the system behind their correspondence.

I did not begin with the arguments. I began with document control, because the weakness in this kind of matter is never the reasoning — it is that a claim cannot be traced back to the document it came from once someone pushes on it. By the time the letters were sent, the register held 582 documents from 17 senders across 19 document types.

Every factual assertion in every letter resolves to a numbered record with a verifiable source. Where it could not, the assertion was not written.

The drafting was done by AI agents I built and directed — Claude-based, each with a defined role and a source gate it cannot argue with. That is why the controls in this document exist: the system is held to the standard you would hold a junior lawyer to, in writing. Nothing went out until I released it — and the register is what makes that supervision honest: any claim in an outgoing document traces to its source without re-reading an archive.

THE CASE THEORY

The authorities have themselves acknowledged in writing that the knowledge base does not hold. Binarise each track, quote verbatim from the authorities' own documents, and compel a written position before the zoning decision.

One sentence, fixed before drafting began, that the whole matter had to survive. It governs what may enter a letter and what may not: a track that does not serve the theory is not a weaker argument, it is a different matter. Every draft was tested against it before it went out.

DELIVERED — LA SANDSFJORDEN LEVA

Association · dust, planning and mediation track

DOCUMENT	SUBSTANCE
Situation Assessment v3.0	Five evidence tracks across three work lines, with a scenario analysis for each procedural outcome.
Action Brief v2.0	Five moves in sequence, each with its own checklist and trigger condition — sequenced so that a missed deadline in one does not collapse the others.

Request for stricter conditions v2.0	Filed with the County Governor on three independent grounds under the Pollution Control Act § 18. Fourteen years of deviation, remedy and renewed deviation, presented as a documented pattern rather than as a complaint.
---	--

DELIVERED — BEVAR ØKSTRAFJORDEN

Association · marine, health and impact-assessment track

Three parallel letters to the County Governor. The design point: each letter carries its own legal basis and addresses its own specialist division, so that no single administrative answer can dispose of all three at once.

LETTER	BASIS AND SUBSTANCE
Letter A — marine baseline	Nature Diversity Act §§ 8–9, Water Regulations § 12, Planning and Building Act § 4-2. Standing anchored in a filed submission and an open case number rather than in a contested complaint — a correction made after the client identified the weakness.
Letter C — freshwater pearl mussel	Nature Diversity Act §§ 8–9, built directly on the authority’s own written finding of a substantial knowledge gap in its 2022 statement.
Letter D — respirable silica	Planning and Building Act § 4-2, deliberately <i>not</i> the Pollution Control Act, to keep the question inside the planning process rather than the permit regime. Built on the municipality’s own admission; the strongest spine in the package.

One evidence track — the freshwater mussel — was deliberately held back from the package and reserved for the later formal submission, to keep the three letters narrow. Scope discipline was treated as a legal decision, not an editorial one.

METHOD

Five phases. Nothing advances until the phase before it has closed.

PHASE	EXIT CONDITION
1 — Scoping	What is actually in dispute, and which authority owns it.
2 — Case theory	One sentence the matter must survive. Revised only deliberately, never drifted.
3 — Document to argument	Every claim bound to a record in the register, with a verbatim quotation.
4 — Adversarial stress test	The other side’s best factual and legal answer, written out in full before the draft is approved.
5 — Tiered output	Released as authority-facing, client-facing or internal — and never above the tier its sources support.

THE REGISTER

One register is the source of truth. Everything downstream points back to it and nothing downstream may outrank it.



A document does not exist until it is in the register

The register carries four states, and the distinction between them is the whole point. Absence is recorded as a value, never left as a silence.

STATE	MEANING
Documented	A verifiable source exists. Only these may carry a hard claim. 424 of 582.
To be verified	Existence itself uncertain. May not be cited. 57.
Registered without document	Known to exist, not held. The gap is a row, not a hole. 55.
Missing	Named, requested, not obtained. Counted, never quietly dropped. 46.

Claims are graded, and grade is a ceiling

Every assertion carries a grade, and no assertion may be presented more strongly than its grade allows: **documented** (primary source read), **secondary** (internal compilation, never load-bearing for a legal conclusion), **assessment**, and **open question**. A finding entering the evidence vault requires a verbatim quotation — no paraphrase — and a second pass that cross-checks it against at least one independent source before it can be used.

Findings are typed by what they prove rather than by subject matter: contradiction, admission, pattern, timeline gap, absent supervision, legal breach. Of 203 findings, the largest class by a wide margin was pattern — which is what a fourteen-year regulatory history actually yields.

Statutes are version-controlled

A decision is tested against the law as it stood on the date the decision was taken, not as it reads today. Statutory provisions are held with their entry-into-force dates, and a citation that would apply a provision to a decision predating it fails rather than passes silently. In a matter spanning 1987 to 2026, this is not a refinement; several of the governing provisions did not exist for most of the period in dispute.

WHAT THIS GENERALISES TO

The hard problem in this work was never retrieval. It was that a claim, a source and a legal basis drift apart over time — a quotation gets tightened, a provision gets amended, a secondary summary hardens into a

primary fact. The controls above exist because in a live adversarial matter, an untraceable claim costs the person making it.

That constraint is not specific to Norwegian planning law. Any system that answers legal questions from a controlled corpus faces the same three questions: does the source exist, does the quotation match it exactly, and was the provision in force at the relevant date. Answer those mechanically and the rest of the argument can be trusted. Leave them to judgement and no amount of downstream reasoning repairs it.

Rune Øverland · runeoverland.no · rune@kaizenstudio.no · 0047 411 67 940

Figures measured against the live registers; document counts as at the date of this document. The two principal client deliverables accompany this case study, reproduced as delivered.